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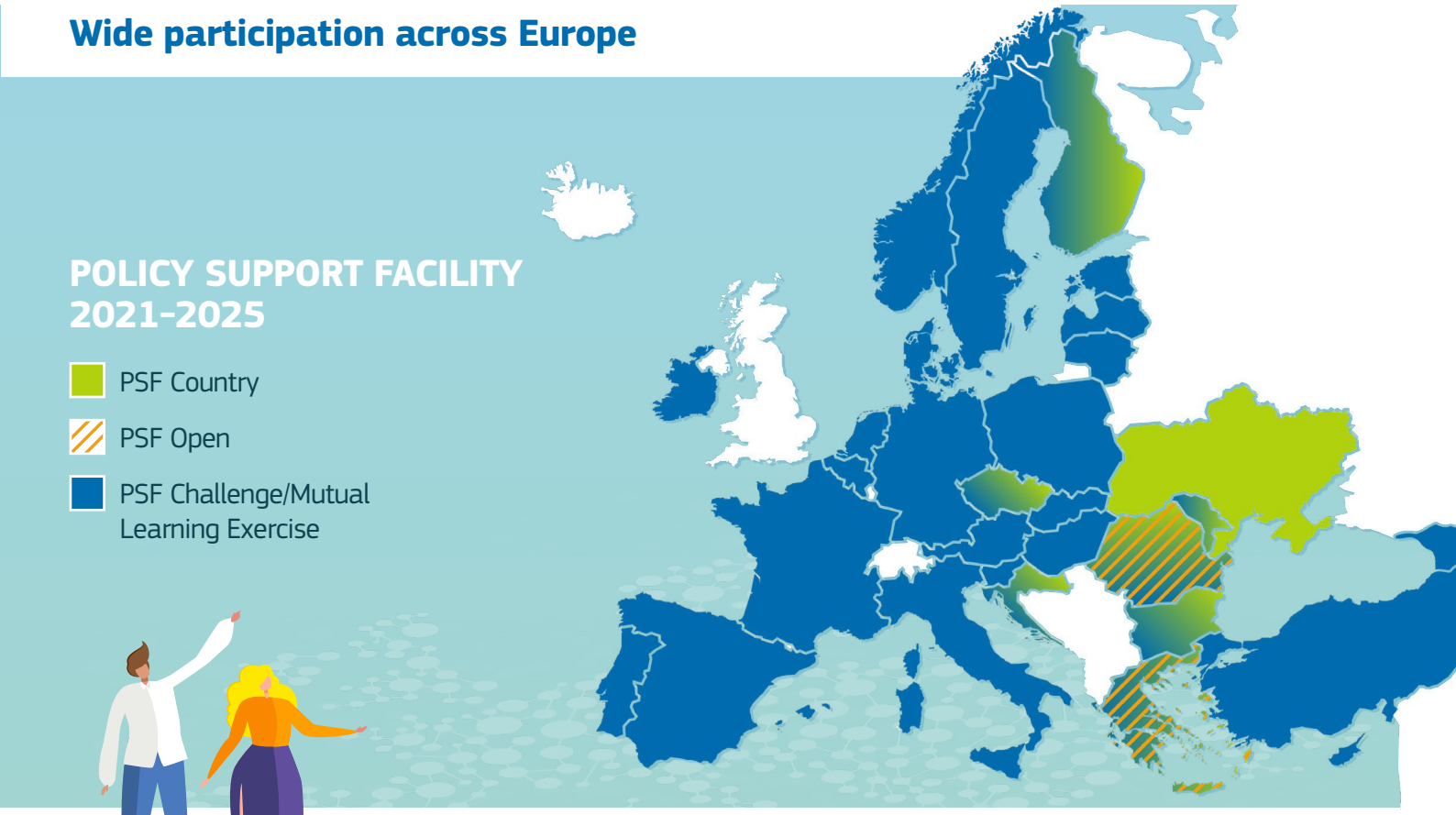
REFORMING RESEARCH AND INNOVATION POLICIES: THE ACHIEVEMENTS OF THE POLICY SUPPORT FACILITY UNDER HORIZON EUROPE



The Policy Support Facility (PSF) offers expert-based support to national authorities in the development and implementation of research and innovation (R&I) policy reforms. Through independent expert advice and mutual learning, the PSF enables countries to advance strategic R&I priorities and strengthen the European Research Area. Under Horizon Europe, the PSF has delivered 21 exercises across 30 EU Member States and associated countries, including:

- **8** PSF Country Reviews
- **11** Mutual Learning Exercises/ PSF Challenge
- **2** PSF Open

Wide participation across Europe





Research and innovation

Advancing evidence-based policy reforms through PSF Country reviews

The PSF has provided tailored support to Member States and associated countries implementing structural reforms in their research and innovation systems. The PSF Country reviews have focused on recurring systemic challenges of national R&I systems such as fragmented governance, under-resourced public research, and limited science-business cooperation. Exercises in countries such as Bulgaria, Croatia, Czechia, Greece, Moldova and Romania delivered recommendations on public funding models, governance frameworks, and knowledge valorisation.

Innovation Leaders[1] also face challenges in their R&I policy and ask PSF for help. Recently Finland requested a PSF review to enhance R&D collaboration between research organisations and the private sector in order to reach its 4% R&D investment target. The PSF provided targeted policy recommendations to reinforce linkages between universities, research organisations and industry.

In **Romania**, the PSF Country Review led to a comprehensive reform process that was part in the national Recovery and Resilience Plan. The main results of this process were the creation of the National Council of Science, Technology and Innovation Policy (CNSTI); the new legislation to streamline the governance and funding of R&I; and the introduction of targeted funding schemes to attract researchers and launched mobility incentives to address brain drain. To support implementation, Romania requested a PSF Open exercise, which further refined the reform agenda.



A key novelty: PSF Open

To strengthen the continuity of policy learning and support the full implementation of research and innovation reforms, the PSF introduced a new service: **PSF Open**. This instrument is designed to help in translating the strategic recommendations of PSF Country reviews into concrete, operational actions.

The first two PSF Open exercises carried out in Romania and Greece demonstrated the added value of this new approach. In Romania, PSF Open contributed to the establishment of a centralised R&I coordination structure under the Prime Minister's authority and supported legislative changes to strengthen research careers, foster brain circulation, and promote internationalisation. In Greece, the exercise informed the design of a national support programme for research infrastructures (2021–2027), embedding principles of open science, digitalisation, and performance-based funding.

"Romania's participation in the various PSF exercises has proven valuable in reshaping our R&I framework, particularly in initiating the drafting of the legislation on the rationalisation of the R&I governance system of the country which was also committed in our Recovery and Resilience Plan. Being part of these activities, working together with the experts, involving the stakeholders in the process allowed us to capitalise on the recommendations and inspires us to incorporate the lessons learned into future policy reforms."

Antonio Radoi, Director Romanian Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalisation



[1] As defined by the European Innovation Scoreboard https://research-and-innovation.ec.europa.eu/statistics/performance-indicators/european-innovation-scoreboard_en

In **Greece**, the PSF supported the national effort to improve the performance and sustainability of its 28 National Research Infrastructures (NRIs). Following the PSF Country Review, Greece introduced a performance-based funding model and updated its national roadmap for NRIs. A follow-up PSF Open exercise helped translate recommendations into implementation plans. In December 2023, the Greek authorities launched a EUR 120 million call for proposals targeting NRIs, using selection criteria aligned with the PSF advice.

"In the call we have adopted most of the recommendations put forward in the PSF studies, including selection criteria, embeding new policies such Open Access, societal impact and the green and digital transition."



Antonios Gypakis, Deputy Head of the Planning and Programming for Research and Innovation Directorate at GSRI

Facilitating Peer Learning and Knowledge Exchange

The PSF Challenge/Mutual Learning Exercises (MLEs) have evolved to reflect the increasing complexity and challenge of Europe's research and innovation policy. The MLEs address a wide array of policy challenges common across countries and that are central to delivering the European Research Area (ERA) and advancing the EU's broader sustainability, competitiveness and digital objectives.

Recent exercises explored the design and implementation of transformative innovation policies-such as industrial decarbonisation, the implementation of EU Missions, and knowledge valorisation-aimed at supporting the twin transitions. Others responded to emerging strategic concerns, including foreign interference in R&I, the role of artificial intelligence in science, and strengthening public engagement and science-policy interfaces. These topics reflect a shift towards more integrated, cross-sectoral, and forward-looking policy support.

Through structured peer learning and expert facilitation, the PSF enables Member States and associated countries to respond to Council conclusions and co-develop actionable solutions, share good practices, and align national reforms with common ERA priorities, including talent circulation, research excellence, knowledge transfer. This evolution confirms the PSF's role as a responsive and strategic instrument for building capacity and supporting effective R&I policy reform across Europe.

PSF Challenge Topics

- Foreign Interference in R&I
- Science for Policy
- EU Missions
- R&I Foresight
- Research Careers
- Industrial Decarbonisation
- Artificial Intelligence
- Knowledge Valorisation
- Citizen Science
- Whole of Government Approach
- Public Engagement in Science







"MLE provided an invaluable exchange of information between member states and with the EC, great guidance of experts, more in-depth understanding of new concepts and contacts for future connections with the knowledge valorisation community in EU"

Mateja Struna, Slovenia, MLE Knowledge Valorisation

Feedback from MLEs participants

As a new element of the MLE process, participating countries provide their feedback on the concept and implementation. Satisfaction surveys[2] confirm the PSF's value and appreciation:

93% of respondents were satisfied or very satisfied

- **85%** reported significantly improved understanding of R&I policy
- **98%** valued the country visits
- **89%** rated reports and expert papers as good or excellent
- **93%** acknowledged the effectiveness of the chairs and experts



Participants praise the PSF for the good quality learning and networking opportunities. An overwhelming majority of the participants found the country visits particularly impactful and valued the discussion papers and thematic reports prepared by the experts. Respondents reported significant improvements in their understanding of the policy issues addressed. They also highlighted the effective facilitation by the international experts and the balanced format combining structured presentations and interactive dialogue as key strengths of the methodology.

Over time, this methodology has been fine-tuned based on feedback and lessons learned. For instance, strengthened attention is paid to allocating enough time for in-depth peer discussions, and structuring them around relevant questions to develop a stimulated debate on challenges, practices and policy options. These fine-tunings have contributed to more focused and balanced exchanges, while maintaining a strong emphasis on shared learning. Participants particularly valued the opportunity to build professional relationships, engage with the R&I communities as well as with other institutions such as the parliamentary committees, and reflect collectively on practical policy challenges.

"My home institution already benefits form the MLE as we are reforming internal policies, which we did based on good examples from the MLE. It is also good to have the possibility to benchmark ourselves to other Member States and to have contacts for future collaboration."

Zuzana Weisgarberova, Czechia, MLE Research Careers

[2] Online survey of participants in seven PSF Mutual Learning Exercises (MLEs) implemented and completed between 2002 and 2024. 47 out of 81 participants responded to the survey. The seven exercises are: MLE on Foreign Interference, MLE on Citizen Science, MLE on Foresight, MLE on Knowledge Valorisation, MLE on National implementation of EU Missions, MLE on Whole-of-Gvt approaches and MLE on Industrial Decarbonisation

Conclusion

The PSF proved to be a successful instrument in supporting Member States and Associated countries in the development and implementation of research and innovation reforms. Its evolution reflects a shift towards challenge driven and demand-oriented approach to better respond to broader socio-economic priorities.

The PSF is increasingly structured around the discussion and delivery of actionable recommendations on specific and emerging R&I challenges. Recent Mutual Learning Exercises proved the flexibility of the tool in responding to emerging EU policy priorities. It supported national strategies on artificial intelligence in science, the development of attractive research careers and the design of industrial roadmaps for decarbonisation. This contribution supports policy agendas aligned with the European Research Area.

Finally, the PSF continues to place strong emphasis on sustainability, follow-up and impact. Beyond the reports, these exercises aim to build long-lasting policy learning capacities. The PSF methodology is increasingly oriented towards implementation and dialogue, providing scope for subject- or country-specific follow-up and strengthening the sustainability of reforms.

Learn more about the Policy Support Facility and how to request support



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